

Preaching for Power: Consequences of Pro-Regime Propaganda by Religious Leaders

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Abstract

What are the consequences of religious leaders promoting state propaganda in authoritarian regimes? This paper argues that propaganda promotion serves as a strategic outreach tool for leaders of religious minority groups to appeal to the broader public. When leaders of politically distrusted groups endorse pro-regime messaging, they signal conformity to the dominant social and political order. This reduces the perceived threat held by the non-religious majority, helping to legitimize the group's position and enhance outreach. However, this strategic signaling risks alienating existing believers who perceive such messages as contradicting core religious principles. I test this argument using two survey experiments in China with Christians as a case study. The results show that non-religious respondents express greater trust in pastors who promote pro-regime messages and report higher openness to religious recruitment from them. Furthermore, these respondents demonstrate greater sympathy when such pastors face repressive measures from the regime. Among Christians, however, pro-regime messaging generates backlash, particularly from long-term converts and frequent attendees. These findings reveal a fundamental dilemma for minority religious leaders under authoritarianism: balancing the need to appeal to outsiders against the necessity of preserving credibility and connection with their own believers.

Introduction

On Sunday, May 7, 2023, hundreds of Chinese Protestant Christians gathered at Jinsha Christian Church in Nantong City, Jiangsu Province. Jinsha Church began as a small gathering of seven Christian women in 1989, who worshiped in a private home, a decade after the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) moved away from its radical anti-religion policy during the Cultural Revolution. After years of fundraising, the congregation achieved a major milestone in 2000 with the construction of its first church building, which can host more than 1,000 worshippers.

The history of Jinsha Church mirrors the remarkable resurgence of Protestant Christianity in China since the 1980s (Yang, 2011). From an estimated population of one million before 1949, the number of Protestants has surged to between 30 and 90 million (Pew Research

Center, 2023), placing China’s Christian population on par with that of Germany or Italy. However, the message echoing from the pulpit suggests that this growth operates within tightening boundaries. Entitled “Adhering to the Sinicization of Christianity and Practicing Socialist Core Values,” it urged the congregation to embrace changes aligning the church with CCP directives. Sinicization represents the Party’s demand to purge Western influences from Christianity, motivated by fears that religion could be exploited by foreign powers to foment anti-regime sentiment (Yang, 2021; Ji and Xuan, 2024). Practicing “Socialist Core Values”, a signature element of Xi Jinping’s contribution to the CCP’s official ideology, demands that religious life conform to the dominant political discourse. Far from being an isolated case, the Jinsha Church sermon exemplifies a growing trend in which Christian leaders incorporate pro-regime messaging into church life, a practice that has intensified since Xi assumed power (Yang, 2021; Jing and Koesel, 2024).

Religious leaders often engage in politics. In electoral settings, they voice views on policy issues (Smith, 2019; Smith and Boas, 2024; Ladini and Faggiana, 2024), endorse candidates whose positions align with them (Smith, 2019; Ravanilla, 2025), provide organizational support for political parties (Kalyvas, 1996; Tuñón, 2020; McDaniel, 2009), and at times seek office themselves (Costa et al., 2019; Boas, 2014). Even in authoritarian governments, many religious leaders and organizations have openly contested state authority (Trejo, 2009; Wood, 1970; Findlay, 1993) and, at times, advocated for liberalization or democratization (Philpott, 2004; Gill, 1998; Rubinstein, 2015; Im, 2020).

However, pro-regime propaganda, as what is observed in some Chinese Christian churches, is categorically different. First, rather than applying religious doctrines to politics, leaders engaged in propaganda align with the regime’s narratives, recast official messaging as sacred imperatives, and in the process often depart from core religious principles. Second, when religious leaders endorse narratives of a regime hostile to the faith community, they signal deference to authorities while registering a moral failure to defend the flock. Overcompliance with authority, whether to foreign occupying forces or authoritarian governments, could erode

leaders' credibility and fuel internal divisions within faith communities (Grzymala-Busse, 2015; Mattingly, 2019).¹

One might expect Christian churches, especially those that promote pro-regime propaganda, to lose appeal among believers, and see their influence wane. Yet focusing solely on the reactions of religious adherents overlooks the broader implications for minority faith communities. For minority groups living in a hostile environment, such as Christians in China, survival and growth depend not only on maintaining internal cohesion but also on securing social acceptance from the majority population.

I argue that for leaders of minority religious groups, particularly those viewed with suspicion due to perceived political disloyalty, aligning with dominant political discourse serves as a signal of conformity to the existing political order, making the group appear more socially acceptable. By projecting a more favorable public image, such alignment not only helps expand recruitment opportunities beyond its traditional base but also garners public sympathy in the face of potential repression from the regime.

However, this strategy entails an internal trade-off. While rhetorical alignment with the regime lowers entry barriers for prospective converts, it risks alienating the group's core constituency. While less committed members may share the outsiders' opinions, more committed members, who constitute the core of the community, are likely to interpret such alignment as a betrayal of religious principles, eroding the leader's spiritual credibility among the most committed.

I evaluate this argument in the context of China, using Christians as a case study. Incorporating information from my fieldwork, I launched two experiments. The findings indicate that propaganda promotion by Christian leaders helps Christians extend the appeal

¹History offers many examples of religious organizations splitting, facing pressure to comply with authoritarian government. In the Soviet Union, Patriarchal Metropolitan Sergius's declaration of loyalty to the Communist regime caused divisions among the clergy, leading to a schism and the rise of the Catacomb Church—an underground Orthodox movement that distanced itself from state control. In China, Christian leaders' excessive compliance with the regime in the 1950s and 60s eroded trust among believers, fueling the growth of House Churches—unregistered congregations operating outside state oversight. Similarly, in Nazi Germany, opposition to the pro-Nazi “German Christians” movement led dissident clergy to establish the Confessing Church.

of their religion to non-religious outsiders, the majority group. It increases not only perceived religious authority and political trust but also openness to Christian recruiting events, often the first step toward conversion in the context of China. Furthermore, non-religious majority members also show greater sympathy for these leaders when they try to resist repressive measures from the government, such as surveillance.

However, Christians' reactions to such pro-regime propaganda are more divided. Propaganda promotion by church leaders diminishes their credibility and reduces the willingness of long-term converts and frequent attendees to choose their churches, whereas newer or less frequent attendees respond more favorably, much like non-Christians. This pattern suggests that resistance to propaganda varies with the strength of religious identity and familiarity with core doctrine, typically built through long-term and frequent religious participation and interactions with peer co-religious.

This study advances our understanding of the intersection of religion and politics in authoritarian contexts. While recent research has explored how religious leaders' messages shape electoral politics,² far fewer studies examine their impact within authoritarian regimes. In such contexts, religious leaders often act as messengers for the regime,³ but the consequences of these messages remain unclear. My findings suggest that for leaders of religious minorities, promoting pro-regime propaganda is a double-edged sword: it may broaden their appeal to outsiders while eroding the trust of committed religious insiders.

This study also speaks to a growing literature on the impact of politics on religiosity. Whereas earlier scholarship often explored how religion shapes political behaviors and attitudes,

²For comprehensive reviews of how religious leaders shape electoral politics, see Sarkar and Coppock (2025) and Djupe and Smith (2018).

³Under Communist rule in Central and Eastern Europe, numerous Christian clergy endorsed Party policies, including collectivization and the confiscation of church property, even adapting their theology to align with the political reality (Ramet, 1998; Wittenberg, 2006). In Putin's Russia, Orthodox clergy have closely aligned with his domestic and international agenda, including support for the invasion of Ukraine, a country that shares a Christian heritage with Russia (Stoeckl, 2016; Amarasinghe, 2021; Kolodiy, 2024; Stoyanov, 2024; Kelaidis, 2023). In Myanmar, Buddhist monks have backed the military junta following its coup (Frydenlund and Wai, 2024). Even minority religious leaders, despite their own constrained freedoms under these regimes, have supported authoritarian rulers. Christian leaders in Syria and Egypt have supported the Assad and Sisi regimes (Farha and Mousa, 2018), while Buddhist leaders in Vietnam have aligned Vietnamese Buddhism firmly with the Socialist ideology (Bui, 2022).

newer research flips the lens, examining how political forces influence religiosity (Hafner and Audette, 2023; Margolis, 2018; Hout and Fischer, 2014; Campbell et al., 2018). Consistent with this line of work, I find that religious socialization changes believers’ reactions to pro-regime rhetoric from their faith leaders. Furthermore, such rhetorical alignment makes non-religious people more open to Christian recruitment, potentially leading to conversion.

More broadly, this study contributes to the literature on society–state relations under authoritarianism by pointing to the core limitation of authoritarian cooptation. Research has documented how authoritarian regimes co-opt civil society groups to consolidate political control (Hassan et al., 2022; Gandhi, 2008; Kim and Gandhi, 2010). Far from fostering democratic habits (Putnam et al., 1994), these co-opted organizations and elites frequently function as extensions of state power, reinforcing the prevailing political order (Mattingly, 2019; Nalepa and Pop-Eleches, 2022; Kim and Gandhi, 2010; Jamal, 2009). However, this study’s findings, which show that pro-regime messaging backfires among devout Christians, reveal a paradox at the heart of co-optation: the more successfully authoritarian regimes transform civil society leaders into state agents, the less influence these leaders wield over their own followers. Over time, this erosion of authority may ultimately weaken the regime’s capacity to control society.

Consequences of Religious Leaders’ Propaganda Promotion

Religious leaders often play influential roles in shaping social and political opinions. In democratic contexts, a substantial body of research shows that their messages can sway public attitudes on a range of issues—from environmental policies (Djupe and Gwiasda, 2010), immigration (Wallsten and Nteta, 2016; DeMora et al., 2024), political tolerance (Grossman et al., 2023), to COVID prevention measures (Adida et al., 2023; Viskupič and Wiltse, 2022), anti-poverty measures (Ladini and Faggiana, 2024), to democratic participation (McClendon

and Riedl, 2019, 2015). Furthermore, endorsements by clergy in various settings have also been shown to influence voting behavior (Boas, 2014; Ravanilla, 2025).

However, far less is known about the impact of religious leaders' political expression under authoritarian regimes, especially when they amplify pro-regime propaganda. Unlike ordinary political expression, where the clergy draws on religious doctrine to interpret policy issues, regime-aligned messaging subordinates religious doctrines to the regime's narratives, often contradicting core religious principles.

What are the consequences of propaganda promotion by religious leaders? Focusing on distrusted minority religious groups, which are perceived as subversive/disloyal to the country and current political order, I argue that responses to propaganda promoted by religious leaders from distrusted minority groups depend on recipients' insider–outsider status. I define insiders as members of the religious community led by the propaganda-promoting clergy, while outsiders are individuals outside the faith, primarily members of the majority population.

Insider Reactions

When forming attitudes and opinions, people often rely on a weighted sample of considerations that are readily accessible to them (Zaller and Feldman, 1992). For religious believers evaluating faith leaders, two considerations are particularly salient: religious authority and moral authority.

Religious leaders are experts in scripture, doctrine, and theology. Sacred texts do not “speak for themselves”; their meanings are forged by traditions refined over generations. Across religions, clergy spend years acquiring the knowledge needed to interpret these texts for their communities. Accordingly, believers expect leaders to deliver messages that are both authoritative and authentic.

Because clergy present themselves as bearers of divine authority and stewards of the sacred, believers look to them not only for abstract religious teaching but also as moral

exemplars. Followers expect concrete guidance for everyday conduct derived from these teachings. Leaders who proclaim such rules are strictly judged by them. When word and deed diverge, the resulting hypocrisy is particularly damaging. Failure to meet the standards they preach erodes trust in both individual clergy and the broader religious institution, which ultimately could lead to a decline in religious participation (Bottan and Perez-Truglia, 2015; Hungerman, 2013; Stroube and Zavyalova, 2025).

Faith leaders who promote pro-regime propaganda fail to meet both of these expectations. Such messages are frequently legitimized through distorted theology. Prominent examples include the German Christian movement portraying Hitler as a messiah (Heschel, 2008), the integration of socialist core values within Chinese churches, the doctrine of dharma-nation-socialism in Vietnam (Bui, 2022), and Patriarch Kirill justifying Russia’s invasion of Ukraine as a holy war (Dubtsova, 2024). Recent literature highlights that the overt politicization of expert domains frequently erodes public trust and accelerates institutional disaffiliation (Schröder, 2023; Clark et al., 2023; Zhang, 2023). This backlash is particularly acute in the religious realm. When clergy align with state narratives in ways that conflict with core doctrine, believers do not passively accept these messages. Instead, they actively evaluate their leaders’ credibility. Upon detecting such doctrinal inconsistencies, believers’ trust in the clergy declines.

Moreover, the moral authority of religious leaders rests on the expectation that they will stand between their community and predatory power, such as foreign occupation or authoritarian rule (Grzymala-Busse, 2015; Wittenberg, 2006; Mattingly, 2019). Promoting pro-regime propaganda signals capitulation and a willingness to trade principles for favor or political expediency. This breach of calling and betrayal of the community’s autonomy and welfare leads to an erosion of religious leaders’ moral standing (Mattingly, 2019).

H1: Religious believers evaluate religious leaders who promote state propaganda more negatively.

Not all believers assign equal weight to the two considerations described above. Whether

people can detect inconsistencies between religious doctrine and pro-regime propaganda depends on their level of religious literacy—that is, a basic understanding of their tradition’s central texts and beliefs. Such literacy, developed through study and engagement with other members of the faith community, equips individuals to judge whether a cleric’s message aligns with sacred teachings. In addition, the strength of a person’s religious identity shapes how they evaluate their leaders. Strongly identifying with a faith community provides a sense of belonging and shared values, and it leads members to adjust their behavior to conform to group norms. Religious believers who strongly identify with their faith are more likely to demand authenticity and resist compliance with regime narratives.

Although religious literacy and identity strength are hard to measure directly, two observable proxies yield testable hypotheses. Both develop over time through repeated interaction with the faith community and sustained participation in religious learning. First, a longer time since conversion should correlate with higher religious literacy and a greater ability to recognize conflicts between doctrine and propaganda. Second, church attendance frequency captures active engagement and exposure to teaching; frequent attenders should be more likely to detect and reject politicized messages from the pulpit.

H1a: Negative effects are stronger among individuals with longer conversion histories and more frequent church attendance.⁴

Outsider Reactions

Besides maintaining trust from their followers, leaders of minority faiths often also need to accommodate and defuse outsider hostility. Following 9/11, Muslims in the United States faced widespread suspicion about their national allegiance, echoing earlier episodes of nativist backlash against German Americans during World War I and Japanese Americans during World War II. In Saudi Arabia, Shi’a Muslims are seen by the Sunni majority as Iranian agents, while in Iran, Sunni Muslims and other minority religious groups such as Jehovah’s

⁴This hypothesis was not pre-registered in the pre-analysis plan; results should be interpreted as suggestive.

Witnesses and Baha'is are often accused of collaborating with foreign powers. In Myanmar, nationalists depict Rohingya Muslims as part of a broader effort to Islamize the country and undermine the Buddhist state (Mukherjee, 2019). Similarly, in China, the rise of Christianity is frequently described by nationalists as evidence of “religious infiltration” orchestrated by Western forces (Pistor-Hatam, 2017).

Mitigating majority hostility is crucial for the survival of minority groups. Public suspicion increases their exposure to violence from the majority (Gravers, 2015; Patil, 2017; Sherman, 1966). State crackdowns on minority groups are more justifiable to the majority group when governments can tap into majority hostility and portray these communities as threats to social stability (Wong, 2024; Lachapelle, 2022; Edwards and Arnon, 2021; Edel and Josua, 2018). In addition, public distrust also constrains minority faith groups’ efforts to conduct outreach and proselytize to sustain and grow their communities. When outsider audiences associate a religious group with foreign interference or disloyalty, they would be more reluctant to associate themselves with the faith.⁵

To mitigate this “trust deficit,” minorities must provide assurances of non-threat to the majority-dominated order and demonstrate a willingness to integrate across social, cultural, and political domains (Brooks, 2019; Fouka, 2019; Hertz, 2007). I argue that one strategy is to align with pro-regime narratives—either by affirming the existing political order or by embracing nationalist rhetoric. It works through two channels: opinion alignment and social expectations.

First, in authoritarian contexts, where official discourses dominate the public sphere, such messaging can resonate with outsiders who have internalized state narratives. Through control of media, education, and public discourse, authoritarian regimes promote official ideology while suppressing alternatives, shaping citizens’ perceptions of regime legitimacy

⁵Historically, proselytization efforts have often been obstructed by perceptions of political subversion. In Qing China, Christian missionaries encountered strong resistance due to their association with foreign powers (Bays, 2011). Similarly, in early 20th-century Mexico, nationalist attacks on Protestantism, which framed it as the expansion of US imperialism in the religious domain, became a major obstacle to the outreach efforts from Protestant missionaries (McIntyre, 2019).

(Mattingly and Yao, 2022; Paglayan, 2022, 2021; Xu and Zhao, 2023; Cantoni et al., 2017). Thus, by promoting propaganda, minority religious leaders signal to regime supporters from the majority group that they are politically aligned with their own political views, which leads to higher trust.

The effects of propaganda promotion by minority religious leaders reach beyond the core supporters of the regime. Even for outsiders who do not fully embrace the regime’s narrative, a minority leader’s conformity to dominant political discourse signals a willingness to comply with the existing political order. Recent studies demonstrate that authoritarian propaganda often serves to signal the regime’s presence and dominance (Huang, 2015; Carter and Carter, 2022). In many cases, propaganda is not simply imposed from above but evolves into a public ritual through grassroots mobilization, sustained by ordinary citizens as a social expectation.⁶ Participation in propaganda promotion, whether coerced or seemingly voluntary, becomes routinized and desensitized. Even those skeptical of official narratives still regard individuals who publicly engage in propaganda as more trustworthy and politically reliable. This pressure is especially intense for groups already suspected to be subversive, whose overt display of allegiance is often scrutinized as a test of their political loyalty.

H2: Outsiders trust religious leaders who promote state propaganda more and are more receptive to outreach efforts from churches led by such leaders.

I also examine treatment heterogeneity. If preferences for propaganda-promoting religious leaders are driven by increased political trust, the effect among outsiders should be strongest among majority members predisposed to distrust the group and those who have internalized regime narratives, such as nationalists. Accordingly, I explore two moderators: pre-existing distrust toward the religious group and levels of nationalism.⁷

H2a: The positive effect of pro-regime propaganda promoted by distrusted

⁶This dynamic recurs in many authoritarian countries. Under Communist rule in Czechoslovakia, greengrocers displayed banners reading “Proletarians of all countries, unite!” as ritualized obedience (Havel, 2018); in Syria, mass rallies functioned as spectacles of devotion to Hafez al-Assad (Wedeen, 2015); and in contemporary China, celebrities routinely repost nationalist propaganda to signal allegiance (Chen and Gao, 2023).

⁷The analysis of nationalism as a moderator was specified in the pre-analysis plan. The analysis of pre-existing distrust is exploratory.

religious leaders is stronger among individuals with low trust in the religious group and among those with high levels of nationalism.

Beyond improving reputational standing, propaganda endorsement may also enhance public sympathy toward minority groups facing repression from authoritarian governments. Authoritarian regimes often justify repression by portraying minorities as threats to social and political order and stability (Wong, 2024; Edwards and Arnon, 2021; Hintz and Ercan, 2024). When minority leaders visibly align themselves with the regime, they challenge this narrative, reducing the perceived legitimacy of state repression and increasing outsider sympathy.

H3: Outsiders are more likely to support religious leaders’ resistance to authoritarian repression when those leaders promote pro-regime propaganda.

Background

This paper examines Christians in China as a case study. Still being a small minority of the population, they are the fastest-growing religious community in China. In 1949, when the Communist Party took power, China had approximately six million Christians. Today, estimates range from 30 to 90 million, accounting for about 2% to 7% of the population.⁸

Since the late 1970s, when the CCP moved away from radical anti-religion policies, Christianity has attracted followers from a highly diverse demographic across the country. In rural areas, the end of collectivization, while boosting productivity, also led to a decline in public goods provision, such as healthcare. Many ill rural residents who could not afford medical treatment turned to Christianity, seeking “divine healing” from Pentecostal or Charismatic pastors believed to be gifted (Liu, 2017; Miller, 2017). In urban areas, laid-off state-owned enterprise (SOE) workers, having lost their “iron rice bowls,” sought solace in spirituality. Meanwhile, educated intellectuals, disillusioned with Communist ideals, looked for new ways to fill the ideological void (Xi, 2013; Kang, 2019, 2016).

The majority of Chinese people, however, remain non-religious and do not identify with

⁸See Pew Research Center (2023) for a detailed discussion of estimates of the Christian population in China.

any established faith. Rather than being strictly atheists, shaped by Communist ideology, many are open to various religious or spiritual practices (Yang and Hu, 2012), and some eventually convert to Christianity. Data from the 2010 Chinese General Social Survey (CGSS), a nationally representative survey, show that 40% of religious individuals did not grow up in religious households. Among Christians, more than half are converts rather than born into Christian families. This relatively “open” religious field creates strong incentives for the Christian community to enhance its public image and broaden its outreach.

However, a major obstacle to outreach efforts is the hostility toward the Christian community held by many non-Christians. This hostility is rooted in Christianity’s historical association with Western imperialism. Beginning in the mid-19th century, Western powers used coercive measures to force China to admit missionaries. The growing missionary presence and expanding Christian community were widely perceived not only as symbols of imperialist expansion but also as threats to China’s traditional social structures, cultural norms, and political stability, fueling deep resentment across social classes (Mattingly and Chen, 2022).

This historical context continues to shape nationalist attitudes toward Christians in modern China. Many nationalists perceive Christianity as a Western religion (Yangjiao) that poses a potential threat to political stability and national unity. The growing Christian population is often framed as a form of “cultural invasion,” with critics suggesting that it could erode Chinese values or even incite political subversion, such as a “color revolution” (Vala, 2017).

Addressing this nationalism-driven hostility is crucial for the Christian community. Hostility toward Christians can easily translate into concrete actions, such as reporting religious activities — whether fully legal or operating in a legal gray zone — to local authorities. Local governments, which might otherwise turn a blind eye, often feel compelled to respond under such pressure, thereby putting the community at risk. Moreover, the perception of Christianity as a foreign religion incompatible with Chinese culture and identity remains a significant obstacle to outreach efforts among non-believers, constraining the growth

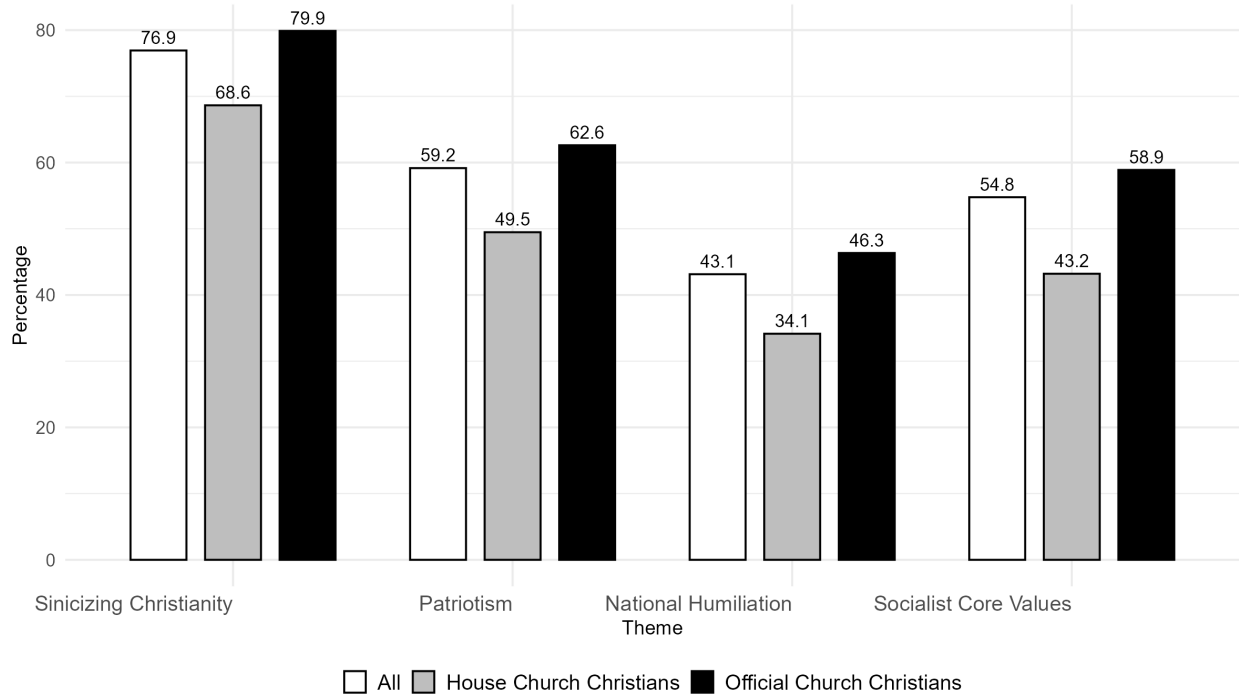
of the religious community.⁹

Many Chinese Christian leaders have viewed alignment with China’s dominant political discourse, whether nationalism or socialism, as a strategy to counter public distrust of the Christian community and the perception of Christianity as a “foreign religion.” For example, Bishop Ding Guangxun (1915–2012), the former president of the Three-Self Patriotic Movement (TSPM), the official umbrella organization of Chinese Protestants, launched the Theological Reconstruction Movement in the 1990s, aiming to replace the conservative theology prevalent in grassroots churches with a liberal theology infused with pro-regime ideology (Wickeri, 2015; Brandner, 2004). More recently, the TSPM launched the “Sinicizing Christianity” movement to reinforce national identity among Chinese Christians (Yang, 2021). Such a rhetorical alignment has also been reflected in the daily experiences of many ordinary Christians in China. In the survey I conducted for this research (Study 1), a large majority of church-attending Christians reported exposure to propagandistic events in their churches (Figure 1).¹⁰

⁹During my fieldwork prior to the survey, many Christian leaders highlighted the widespread perception of Christianity as a foreign religion as a major barrier to outreach and conversion.

¹⁰More information about the survey could be found in the next section.

Figure 1: Percentage of Respondents Reporting Event Themes



Note: Data comes from an original survey of church-attending Chinese Christians, including 287 Christians who attend house churches and 805 of them attending TSPM churches (Total N = 1092). More information on the survey can be found in the next section. Respondents were asked whether they had encountered sermons or events about these topics in their churches.

I do not claim that all Christian leaders who promote pro-regime messaging do so purely out of strategic calculation. In some cases, government pressure is undeniable. For example, the movement to “Sinicize Christianity,” launched by TSPM, also closely aligns with the party’s broader policy of “religious Sinicization,” a policy that aims to reduce perceived foreign influence in religion (Yang, 2021). However, top-down pressure alone does not fully account for the motives behind many grassroots Christian leaders’ promotion of pro-regime messaging. Due to limited resources, the state’s approach to Christian churches is characterized more by constraint than by comprehensive control (Reny, 2018). Most of the time, Christians worship and hold activities in churches without direct oversight from state officials, as long as no direct political threat is detected. Moreover, if top-down pressure were the sole driver, we

would expect the politicization of religion to appear only in TSPM (official) churches. Yet my survey shows that many Christians who attend house churches—those not under direct government oversight—also encounter pro-regime messaging, albeit to a lesser extent.¹¹

What do religious leaders stand to gain by endorsing propaganda, and at what cost to their credibility, authority, and community cohesion? These are the questions my experiments will tackle.

Empirical Design

To examine how Christians and non-religious majority individuals respond to propaganda promoted by Christian leaders, I conducted two surveys in late 2024 to early 2026, in collaboration with a commercial survey firm in China.¹²

Study 1

In study 1, I recruited 1,404 non-religious respondents using stratified sampling quotas based on gender, age, and region, and 1,112 Christian respondents without demographic quotas, given the difficulty of accessing this smaller population.¹³

Despite the use of quotas, the final non-religious sample skews younger than the national average, with fewer older respondents than intended, and an overrepresentation of college-educated individuals.¹⁴ In terms of geographic distribution, both the Christian and non-

¹¹This finding aligns with Koesel (2014), who also found that house church Christians in China sometimes deliberately employed pro-regime and nationalistic messaging to appeal to the public.

¹²Although concerns over the external validity of online surveys have been raised, studies have shown that online surveys are valid in different contexts, including China (Berinsky et al., 2012; Li et al., 2018).

¹³As specified in the pre-analysis plan, the initial target for the Christian sample was 500 respondents based on vendor feasibility. Due to a higher-than-expected response rate during recruitment, I expanded this target to 1,100 to maximize statistical power. To ensure data quality, the survey utilized embedded attention checks, yielding a 98% pass rate. Furthermore, I validated the Christian subsample with a mandatory screening question requiring respondents to correctly identify the four Gospels in the New Testament. Over 97% of self-identified Christians passed this verification.

¹⁴The overrepresentation of urban, younger, and highly educated respondents does not undermine the central findings of this study for three reasons. First, this demographic is more likely to encounter regime-aligned messages in practice. Urban churches whose members tend to be younger and more educated are typically led by more educated clergy who are better equipped to articulate and deliver such pro-regime messages.

religious samples are diverse and closely mirror the national population. Detailed demographic characteristics are provided in Appendix A.

Respondents first answered questions regarding basic demographic characteristics, including gender, age, and education. This was followed by several attitudinal measures to assess levels of nationalism and, for non-religious respondents, their attitudes toward the Christian community. For Christian participants, the survey included additional questions on church attendance and conversion history. Following these sections, the conjoint experiment was administered.¹⁵

Conjoint Experiment

The conjoint experiment examines how propaganda promotion shapes the evaluations of Christian leaders by non-religious individuals and Christians (Hypotheses 1 and 2). In a conjoint experiment, participants evaluate a series of profiles defined by multiple attributes, with the levels of each of their attributes randomly assigned. Conjoint experiments are particularly suited to studying multi-dimensional preferences (Hainmueller et al., 2014; Abramson et al., 2022), such as evaluations of religious leaders. Such a design could mitigate social desirability bias, a common challenge in authoritarian contexts (Horiuchi et al., 2022). Because participants are asked to choose between profiles without needing to explain their decisions, the design reduces pressure to conform to socially expected answers as it provides plausible deniability when they select or avoid sensitive attributes.

This design is particularly appropriate for studying how propaganda promotion shapes church choice among Christians in China, where such choices are common in real life. Similar to Protestants in the United States, the decentralized structure of Protestantism in China fosters high inter-church mobility, making pastors’ teaching and charisma major factors in “church-shopping.” This tendency is further reinforced by the absence of strong denominational

Second, robustness checks (Appendix D) demonstrate that the estimated effects remain stable across age and education strata, confirming that the findings are not an artifact of the sample composition.

¹⁵The experiment has been pre-registered at the Open Science Framework. This study has been approved by the Institutional Review Board of the author’s institution.

traditions in the Chinese Christian community, which elsewhere often deters individuals from leaving churches aligned with their denominational identity.¹⁶

In my conjoint experiment, respondents were presented with the profiles of two hypothetical pastors, each containing randomly generated attributes across five categories, comprising a total of fourteen levels. All of the attributes can be found in Table 1.

The primary attribute of interest is the title of the pastor’s most recent sermon, which takes one of four values. All sermon titles were drawn from real sermons, either attended in person during my fieldwork prior to the survey or sourced from churches’ online postings. Two of the sermons are explicitly political: “Adhere to the Sinicization of Christianity and Adapt to Socialist Society” and “Never Forget National Humiliation, Remember History.” Both convey pro-regime messages, but with subtle differences. The first reflects the Chinese Communist Party’s (CCP) directive for churches to purge “Western influence” and align more closely with the current political order, an agenda rooted in the state’s concern that religion might be used by foreign powers to incite anti-regime sentiment (Yang, 2021). The second sermon title advances a nationalist narrative, invoking the historical memory of China’s “Century of Humiliation” (1840s–1940s), a period marked by foreign aggression and subjugation that, according to official discourse, ended with the CCP’s rise to power.

To provide a contrast, I included two non-political sermon titles: “Love Can Create Miracles” and “Jesus Is the Path, the Truth, and the Life.” The first one, a non-political sermon without explicitly Christian language in its title, helps control for the possibility that differences in responses to political and apolitical sermons are driven by anti-religion sentiment, rather than by preferences for pastors who promote pro-regime messaging.

¹⁶Higgins and Djupe, 2022. The absence of denominational identities among most Chinese Christians is the result of the unique historical trajectory of Christianity in China. During the “Great Leap Forward” in the late 1950s, as the CCP mobilized all available resources to support Mao’s industrialization agenda, many churches were confiscated for alternative uses, such as factories and schools. Christians from diverse denominational backgrounds were compelled to worship together. Since then, the Three-Self Patriotic Movement (TSPM)—the state’s corporatist umbrella organization for Protestant churches—formally abolished denominational distinctions. Today, aside from a small minority distinguished by theologies and practices often deemed “heretical” by mainstream Chinese Christians, most Christians in China lack strong denominational identities that might otherwise discourage “church-shopping.”

Table 1: Conjoint Attribute

Attribute	Levels
Age	33, 49, 65
Gender	Male (男), Female (女)
Other Position	Seminary professor (神学院教授) Vice Chairman of Consultative Conference’s Committee on Religious Affairs (市政协宗教事务委员会副主任) Christian Nursing House president (基督徒养老院院长)
Education	Bachelor from Chinese seminary (中国某神学院本科) PhD from Chinese seminary (中国某神学院博士) PhD from US seminary (美国某神学院博士)
Recent Sermon Title	Jesus is the way, truth, and life (耶稣是道路，真理，生命) Love can create miracles (爱能创造奇迹) Never forget national humiliation, remember history (勿忘国耻，铭记历史) Sinicize Christianity, adapt to Socialist society (坚持基督教中国化，适应社会主义社会)

In addition to sermon titles, the profiles included several other attributes that could shape respondents’ perceptions of the hypothetical pastors, including gender,¹⁷ age, educational background, and other positions.

The conjoint experiment includes three sections, each asking respondents to evaluate four pairs of hypothetical Christian pastors in a different dimension.¹⁸

¹⁷In China, female ordination is very common, and female clergy outnumber male clergy within the official TSPM system. This phenomenon is caused by a shortage of men interested in ministry.

¹⁸I deviate from the common practice of asking multiple questions about the same pair of profiles. This standard approach risks priming respondents to select the same profile across different questions. To minimize potential carryover effects, I present newly generated profiles across three separate sections.

First, I asked respondents to select the Christian pastor they perceived as more religiously authoritative. I asked respondents to choose “the religious figure that can more authoritatively and accurately deliver the information of their religion.”

The second question tests whether propaganda promotion has potential behavioral consequences for both Christians and non-Christians. The phrase varies slightly for non-Christians and Christians. For Christians, the question asks them to choose between two churches led by different hypothetical pastors. For non-religious respondents, the experiment presents a hypothetical scenario in which their best friend, a Christian, invites them to a church event hosted by two pastors. Respondents are then asked to indicate which event they would be more likely to attend.

Both questions are designed to mirror the real-world dynamics of religious diffusion in China. Given the prohibition on public proselytizing, private network-based invitations are effectively the only legal conduit for outsiders to encounter the church (Sun, 2017). While distinct from conversion itself, accepting such an invitation constitutes a necessary behavioral precursor for religious conversion, and a refusal effectively terminates the trajectory toward conversion. Therefore, this measure captures initial receptivity, which is the indispensable first step in the recruitment process.

For most Chinese Christians, as previously noted, denominational identities are vague or absent, contributing to high levels of inter-church mobility. One of the primary factors influencing church choice is the evaluation of pastoral leadership, with dissatisfaction toward pastors frequently motivating believers to switch churches.

The third conjoint section investigates whether propaganda promotion mitigates concerns regarding political allegiance. This is proxied by respondents’ perceptions of each pastor’s patriotism (measured on a 1–7 scale). Given that religious minorities in authoritarian regimes are often viewed with suspicion of ‘dual loyalty,’ patriotism measures the core concern of the majority: alignment with the nation-state. Consequently, higher perceived patriotism functions as a robust signal of non-subversion and rule compliance.

Table 2: Conjoint Dependent Variables

Conjoint Questions	Scale	Non-religious Respondents	Christians
Religious Authority	Dummy	X	X
Church Choice	Dummy		X
Openness to Christian Recruitment	Dummy	X	
Perceived Patriotism	1–7 scale rating	X	

Note: “X” indicates that the dependent variable was measured for the respective respondent group.

Figure 2: Conjoint Illustration

The table below presents background information on two Christian figures.

	Figure A	Figure B
Age	49	49
Gender	Female	Male
Education	PhD from a U.S. seminary	PhD from a Chinese seminary
Other Position	Deputy Director, Municipal Committee on Ethnic & Religious Affairs	President, Christian Nursing Home Seminary
Theme of Recent Sermon	Love can create miracles	Uphold the Sinicization of Christianity, adapt to socialist society

Which of the two do you think is more trustworthy in disseminating religious information?

Figure A

☐

Figure B

☐

Study 2: Propaganda and Resistance to Repression

Study 2 tests Hypothesis 3 by examining the political consequences of pro-regime propaganda within the context of state repression. While Study 1 analyzed the evaluations of clergy and their behavioral implications, Study 2 shifts the focus to how signaling political loyalty affects public sympathy for religious leaders facing government intrusion.

In early 2026, I recruited a separate sample of $N = 1,409$ non-religious respondents via the same commercial survey firm used in Study 1. The recruitment employed identical stratified sampling quotas for gender, age, and region to ensure population representativeness.

Experimental Design: Authoritarian Surveillance

State repression against minority groups often receives public support from majority outsiders when those minorities are perceived as threatening or subversive. Study 2 focuses on surveillance as the primary form of repression. In recent years, the Chinese government has increasingly relied on digital surveillance to exert social control. Places of worship are key targets for such monitoring. Christian churches and mosques are frequently equipped with surveillance cameras and facial recognition systems to record the identities and speech of attendees (Xu, 2021). Church leaders who refuse to comply with these mandates often face government reprisals, including the revocation of their official religious worker status.

The choice of authoritarian surveillance as the focus of Study 2 rests on two considerations. First, surveillance represents a pervasive and institutionalized method of social control, whereas more overt forms of political violence may reflect idiosyncratic local governments' overreach. Second, surveillance remains a subject of limited but permissible public discourse in China. Citizens frequently navigate the trade-off between social stability and individual privacy (Su et al., 2022), making this topic less susceptible to social desirability bias than more sensitive categories of state repression.

This experimental vignette presents a scenario in which a Christian pastor faces a

government mandate to install surveillance cameras in his church. The content of the pastor's prior sermon is randomized across three conditions. In the control group, the pastor delivers a purely religious sermon unrelated to politics. In the two treatment groups, the pastor delivers political sermons. In the first treatment group, the pastor invokes a nationalist theme and calls on Christians to defend against foreign infiltration. In the second treatment group, the pastor emphasizes the necessity for Christians to conform to the prevailing political order.

In the control condition, respondents read the following description:

Zhang is a Christian pastor. Last Sunday, Zhang conducted a worship service at the church and delivered a sermon titled Jesus is the Truth, the Way, and the Life, through which he encouraged the believers to confront the various difficulties of life by means of prayer, loving others, and placing their trust in God.

The experimental treatments introduced political themes into the sermons, with the first condition focusing on nationalist rhetoric:

Zhang is a Christian pastor. Last Sunday, Zhang delivered a sermon titled Never Forget National Humiliation, Remember History. He reviewed the history of humiliation in modern China and called on believers to remain vigilant against the infiltration of foreign forces and to safeguard national dignity.

The second treatment group centered on the requirement for Christians to conform to the prevailing political order:

Zhang is a Christian pastor. Last Sunday, Zhang delivered a sermon titled Love the Party, Love the Country, and Love Socialism. He cited religious doctrines to elaborate on how believers should support the socialist system and emphasized that being a good Christian first requires being a good citizen.

After the description of the sermon, all respondents were informed of the government's intervention:

Recently, his church was required by higher authorities to install surveillance cameras to record the pastor’s words and deeds on the pulpit, especially remarks that are detrimental to social harmony and stability.

The experiment then stated that Zhang considers these cameras unnecessary and a violation of the privacy of the congregation. Respondents were asked to indicate their level of agreement with Zhang’s view on a scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree).

Propaganda Promotion Improves Outsiders’ Perceptions

For the conjoint experiment, I use the Average Marginal Component Effect (AMCE) (Hainmueller et al., 2014) as my primary estimator. Because each respondent evaluates multiple profiles, I cluster standard errors at the respondent level. Results are presented visually, focusing on the contrast between propaganda and non-propaganda sermons. In the main text, I pool the two non-propaganda sermon themes and the two propaganda sermon titles. The full AMCE results appear in Appendix C, and the full Marginal Means for subgroup analyses are reported in Appendix D1.

I first focus on the results of the conjoint experiment, focusing on non-religious people.

Figure 3: AMCE: Non-religious



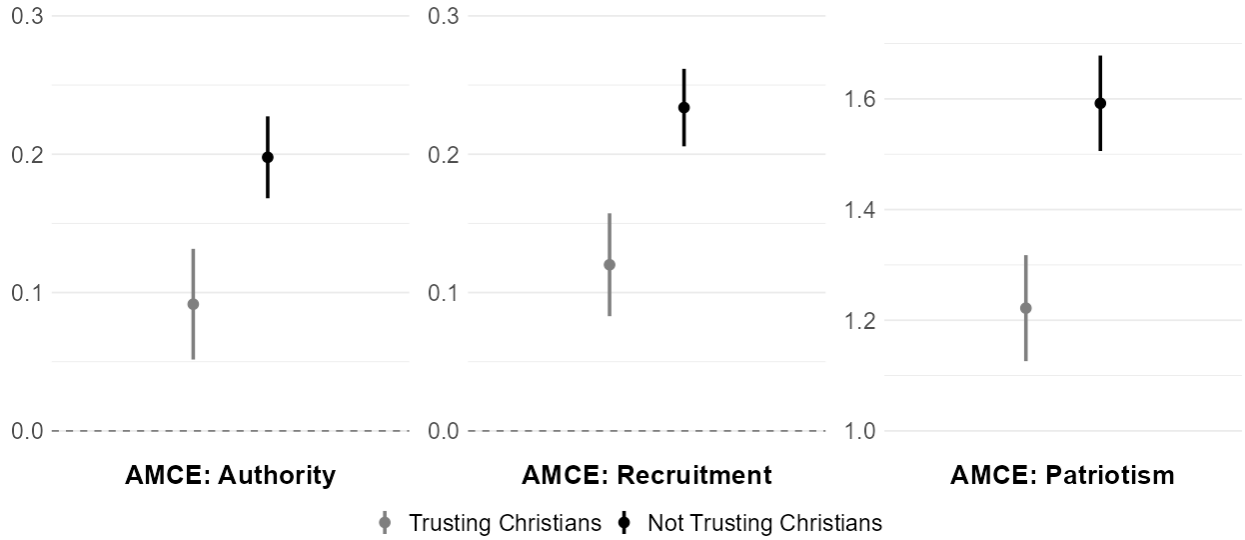
Note: Coefficients are Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs) of propaganda sermon titles relative to non-propaganda titles, estimated via OLS. The first two dependent variables are binary forced-choice outcomes; the patriotism rating is measured on a 1–7 scale.

Figure 3 presents the AMCE of propaganda sermons, relative to non-propaganda sermons, for three outcomes among non-religious respondents: perceived religious authority, openness to religious recruitment, and political trust. The findings indicate that promoting propagandistic sermons effectively enhances the perceived image of Christian leaders among non-religious respondents. Compared to non-propaganda sermons, a Christian pastor who preaches propaganda is 15% more likely to be considered religiously authoritative. The results also suggest that an improved image of Christian leaders among non-religious individuals has important behavioral implications: it benefits church outreach and recruitment efforts. Compared to pastors who do not promote propaganda, those who do are 18% more likely to attract respondents to attend church events when invited by a friend. Additionally, profiles promoting propaganda were rated as significantly more politically trustworthy. On a 1–7 scale, these profiles were perceived as 1.45 points more patriotic.

I also examine treatment heterogeneity among non-religious respondents along two pre-treatment moderators. While the analysis for nationalism was pre-registered, the examination

of the ex-ante perceived level of patriotism is exploratory. My theory implies that propaganda aligns with the political beliefs of core regime supporters (nationalists). Accordingly, respondents with stronger nationalist sentiment, whose views are closer to propaganda narratives, should be more receptive to such messages by Christian leaders. Furthermore, the theory also implies that concern over the political allegiance of the Christian community is the key mechanism behind positive reactions to propaganda promoted by Christian leaders; therefore, respondents who view Christians as less patriotic should respond more favorably to propaganda promotion.¹⁹

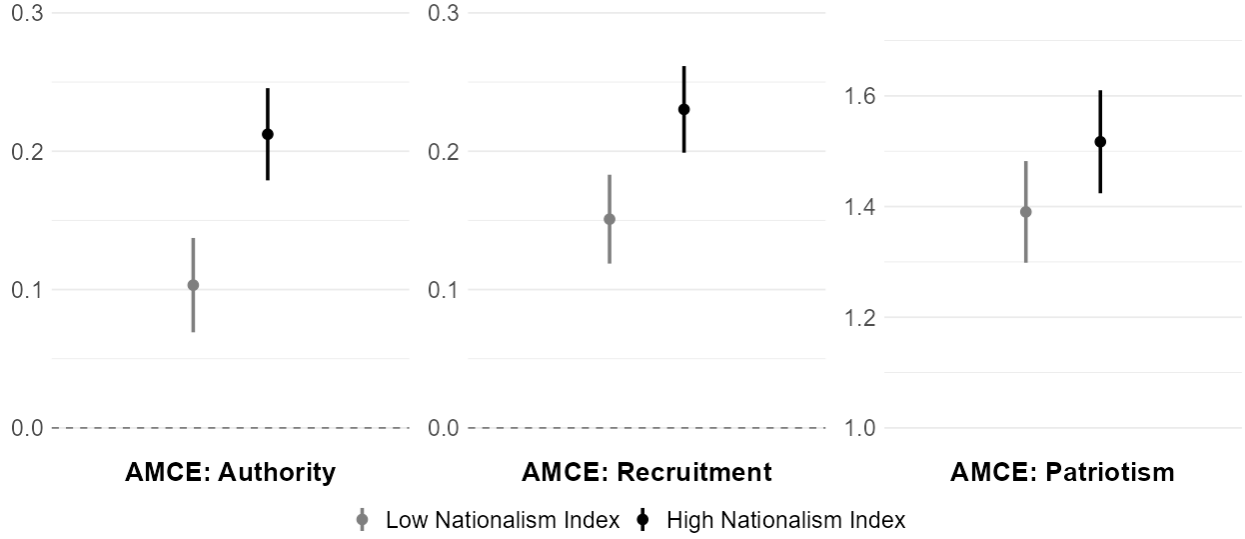
Figure 4: Subgroup by Trust in Christians



Note: Coefficients are Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs) of propaganda sermon titles relative to non-propaganda titles, estimated via OLS. The first two dependent variables are binary forced-choice outcomes; the patriotism rating is measured on a 1–7 scale.

¹⁹Nationalism is measured using three items from Huang and Liu (2018). I construct an index, using Principal Component Analysis (PCA) and split respondents at the median into “high” and “low.” Details and PCA results are in Appendix B. I ask how patriotic Christians are as a group: very/somewhat unpatriotic, somewhat/very patriotic. Among non-religious respondents, 61% rate Christians as unpatriotic and 39% as somewhat/very patriotic. I code the latter as “high trust” and the former as “low trust.”

Figure 5: Subgroup by Nationalism



Note: Coefficients are Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs) of propaganda sermon titles relative to non-propaganda titles, estimated via OLS. The first two dependent variables are binary forced-choice outcomes; the patriotism rating is measured on a 1–7 scale.

The subgroup results (Figures 4–5) show a clear pattern. Across outcomes, non-religious respondents with low political trust in Christians—those most eager for compliance signals—respond more positively to propaganda sermons. This suggests that such messaging boosts perceived authority and openness to outreach by raising political trust.

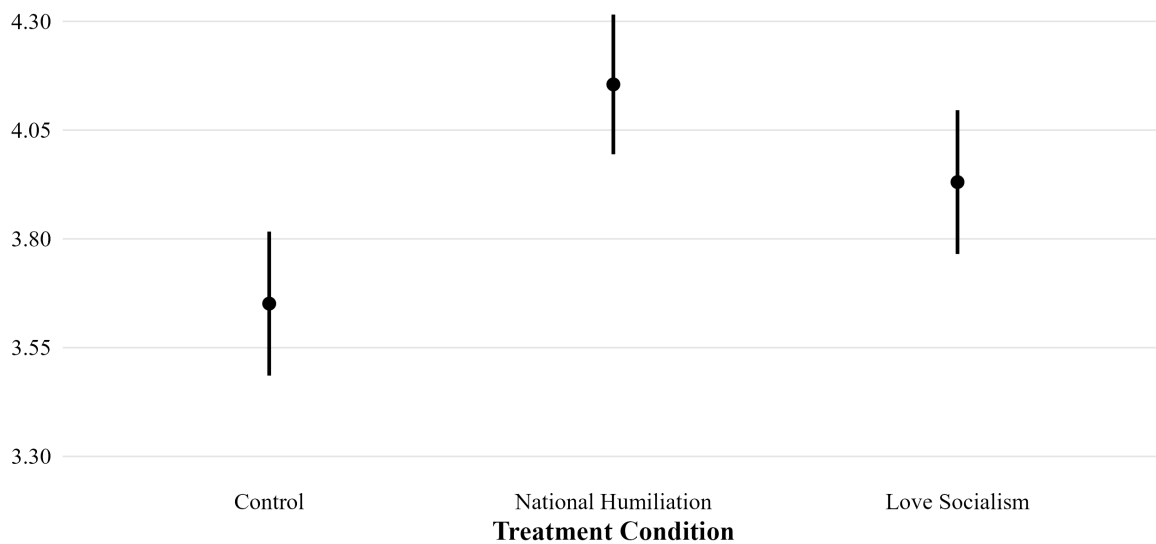
Similarly, more nationalist respondents, whose views align with regime narratives, react more favorably to the nationalist sermon. Strikingly, even less nationalist respondents, who may resist the regime’s legitimization story, still evaluate propaganda-promoting pastors more positively. Consistent with the theory, the benefits are not confined to ideologically aligned audiences: by echoing dominant political messaging, Christian leaders normalize themselves and appear less subversive to outsiders.

Propaganda Promotion and Support for Resistance to Repression

The results of the vignette experiment, presented in Figure 6, show the estimated effects of both treatment conditions relative to the control group. Those in the control group remained

relatively neutral, with an average score of 3.9 on a 1–7 scale. Consistent with my expectations, respondents were more likely to sympathize with pastors who openly signaled political loyalty in their sermons. Compared to the control group, respondents who were told that the pastor delivered a sermon on “Never Forget National Humiliation,” a nationalist theme, expressed 0.503 points more support for the pastor’s concerns. Similarly, those informed that the pastor preached on “Love the Party, Love the Country, and Love Socialism” showed an increase of 0.279 points in support. These results suggest that propaganda promotion, by signaling political conformity and loyalty, can reduce out-group suspicion and diminish support for repression against distrusted minority groups.

Figure 6: Propaganda Promotion Increases Support for Resistance to Surveillance



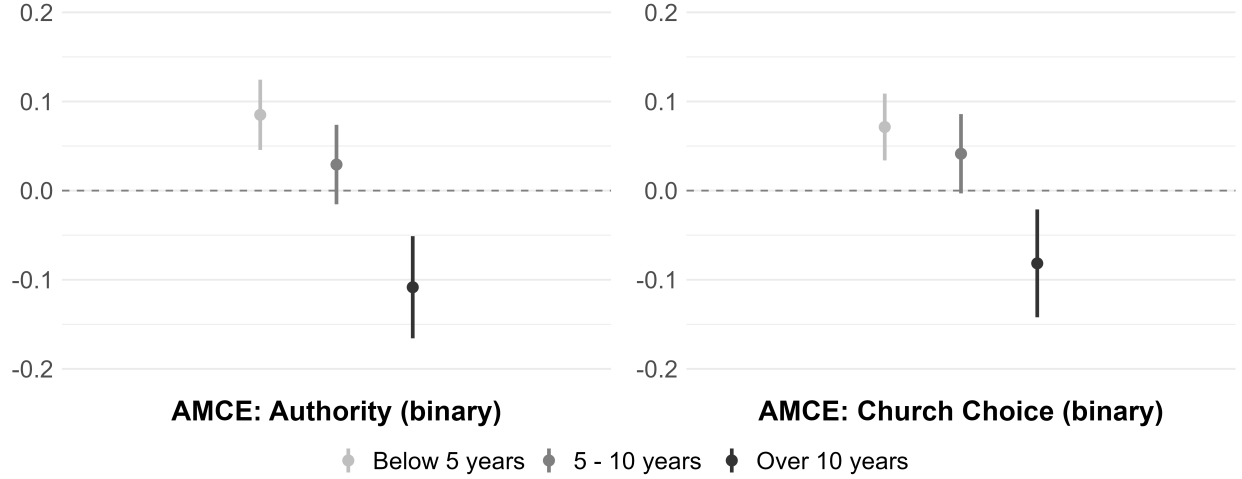
Note: Group averages are presented with 95% confidence intervals. The dependent variable is the level of support respondents show to the pastor, ranging from 1–7.

Christians’ Reactions to Propaganda Promotion are Divided

Having shown that propaganda can improve Christian leaders’ standing among non-religious outsiders, I now turn to its potential costs. Against my pre-registered hypothesis, figure

7 shows that relative to non-propaganda sermons, propaganda sermons produce small, statistically insignificant increases in perceived religious authority and in church choice.

Figure 7: AMCE: Christians



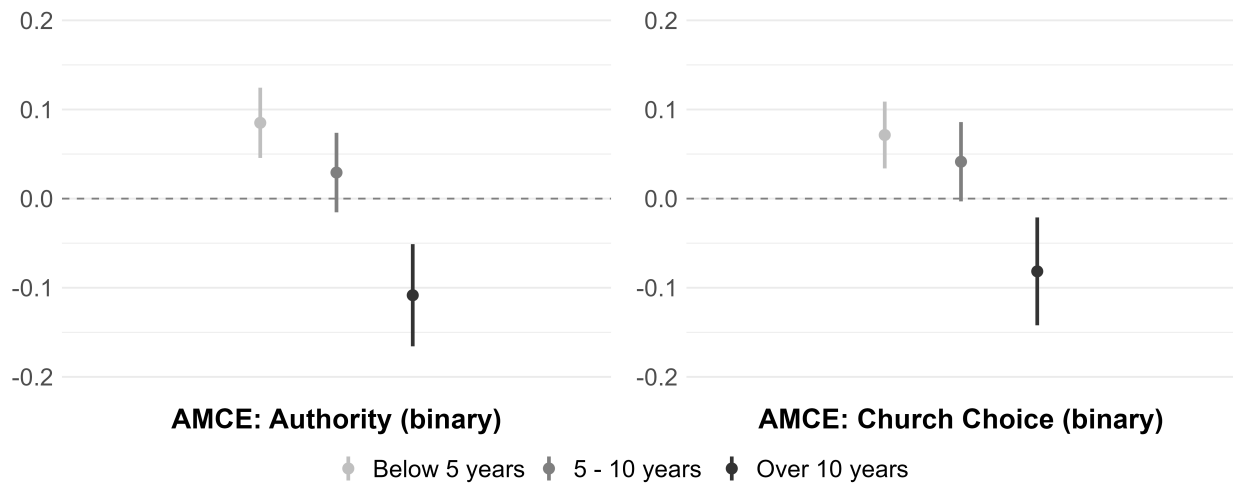
Note: Coefficients are Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs) of propaganda sermon titles relative to non-propaganda titles, estimated via OLS. The first two dependent variables are binary forced-choice outcomes; the patriotism rating is measured on a 1–7 scale.

Does this imply that promoting propaganda is cost-free for Christian leaders in China? Not necessarily. Aggregate effects can mask meaningful heterogeneity within the Christian community. In an exploratory analysis (not pre-registered), I examine two conditions that theoretically shape insiders' negative reactions to clergy-led propaganda. First, believers must anchor their self-understanding in the faith (an insider identity). Second, they need basic religious literacy, typically developed through participation and long-term interaction with the community. Two measures speak to these mechanisms: time since conversion and frequency of church attendance. Recent converts may look similar to non-Christians, but as faith deepens, tensions between state propaganda and core doctrine should become more salient and the messaging less appealing. Likewise, more frequent attenders are more likely to detect politicization of the faith and to react negatively to propaganda delivered in church.²⁰

²⁰Conversion history: < 1 year (N=44), 1–5 years (N=463), 5–10 years (N=352), > 10 years (N=252). Because the < 1 year group is small, I combine it with the 1–5 year group in the analysis. Attendance: monthly (N=423), weekly (N=281), less than monthly (N=408).

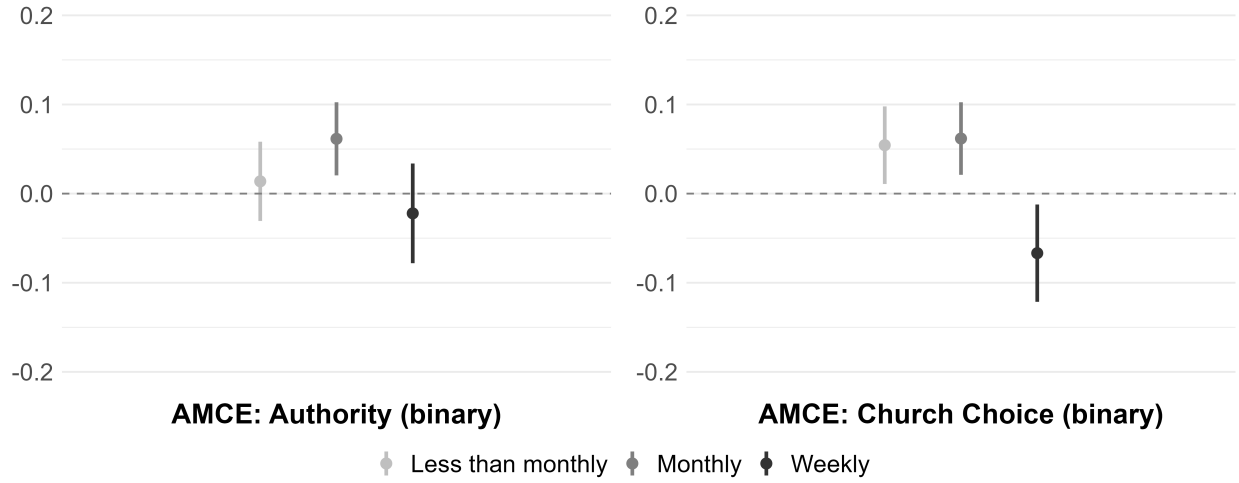
Figures 8 and 9 present the results of the subgroup analysis by conversion history and church attendance, revealing a consistent pattern. The longer a Christian has been converted, the more likely they are to react negatively to propaganda promotion by Christian leaders. Among those who converted within the past five years, propaganda promotion has a positive effect. In contrast, for Christians who have converted for 10 years or more, propaganda promotion significantly undermines leaders' credibility. These leaders are 10% less likely to be perceived as religiously credible and 9–10% less likely to attract Christians to their churches.

Figure 8: Subgroup by Attendance Frequency



Note: Coefficients are Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs) of propaganda sermon titles relative to non-propaganda titles, estimated via OLS. The first two dependent variables are binary forced-choice outcomes; the patriotism rating is measured on a 1–7 scale.

Figure 9: Subgroup Analysis by Conversion Time



Note: Coefficients are Average Marginal Component Effects (AMCEs) of propaganda sermon titles relative to non-propaganda titles, estimated via OLS. The first two dependent variables are binary forced-choice outcomes; the patriotism rating is measured on a 1–7 scale.

A similar pattern emerges when considering church attendance. Christians who attend services more frequently react more negatively to propaganda sermons than those who attend less often. Although the estimates for the authority evaluation question are not statistically significant, weekly churchgoers are substantially less likely to choose churches where pastors promote pro-regime messaging. In this group, propaganda sermons reduce the likelihood of selecting the profile by approximately 6%, whereas responses among less frequent attendees are generally more positive.

Taken together, the subgroup analysis suggests that propaganda promotion by Christian leaders generates particularly negative reactions among more committed Christians, those with longer conversion histories and those who attend church more often.

Addressing Alternative Explanations

Social Desirability Bias

Social desirability bias poses a fundamental challenge to survey research in authoritarian contexts. In such regimes, individuals frequently conceal their true opinions or falsify preferences to ensure political safety (Kuran, 1998). Consequently, there is a risk that respondents will report positions they perceive as politically acceptable rather than those they genuinely hold (Nicholson and Huang, 2022; Jiang and Yang, 2016; Li et al., 2025). In this study, this dynamic could lead to an artificial overreporting of preferences for pastors who promote regime-aligned information.

While social desirability bias cannot be entirely eliminated, this paper employs several strategies to mitigate its influence. First, I utilize a conjoint experiment, a design empirically shown to significantly reduce social desirability pressures by providing respondents plausible deniability (Horiuchi et al., 2022). Within this framework, a respondent who selects a pastor avoiding regime-aligned rhetoric can implicitly justify their choice through non-political attributes, such as gender, age, or education, rather than explicitly revealing a political attitude.

Furthermore, if the results were driven by social desirability and self-censorship, one would expect the propaganda sermon’s positive effects to be stronger among groups identified in the literature as most susceptible to such pressures. For instance, Shen and Truex find that marginalized populations, including women and the elderly, are more likely to self-censor (Shen and Truex, 2021). However, the subgroup analyses in Appendix D reveal the opposite pattern. Among both Christian and non-religious respondents, differences between genders are minimal; in fact, non-religious male respondents display slightly more favorable views toward propaganda-promoting pastors than their female counterparts (Table A.10). Similarly, regarding age, the positive effects are actually more pronounced among younger respondents (Tables A.9 and A.11).

Finally, the vignette experiment is specifically designed to preempt potential social desirability bias regarding state repression. To mitigate the risk that respondents might overstate their support for repressive measures to appear politically compliant, the experiment focuses on the deployment of public security cameras. Despite the restrictive information environment in China, the state permits public debate concerning the expansion of surveillance systems (Su et al., 2022). Furthermore, framing the opposition through the lens of privacy concerns, which is a relatively non-political issue, provides respondents with a safer avenue to express dissent.

Additional Analysis for Subgroup Heterogeneity among Christians

The analysis demonstrates that the influence of regime-aligned information on Christian respondents is conditional upon two key factors: conversion duration and church attendance frequency. I posit that these metrics serve as proxies for religious socialization, a process that consolidates religious identity and enhances theological literacy, thereby reshaping believers' responses to state-aligned narratives in the church.

A potential alternative explanation, however, is that these subgroup differences are artifacts of demographic confounding rather than religiosity per se. Specifically, age is positively correlated with both attendance frequency and the length of conversion history. Consequently, the observed heterogeneity could theoretically reflect generational cohorts rather than religious socialization.

To rule out this possibility, I conduct a robustness check comparing baseline results against models explicitly controlling for interactions between profile attributes and age. The intuition is straightforward: if age drove the results, including a treatment-by-age interaction should attenuate the explanatory power of conversion history and religious attendance. The results, however, indicate that the core findings remain robust even after controlling for these demographic interactions (see Appendix D.2).

Finally, I examine whether the institutional environment of socialization moderates these

outcomes by comparing attendance at officially sanctioned churches versus independent house churches. As detailed in Appendix E, Christians attending official churches generally respond more positively to pro-regime messaging. However, the moderating effects of conversion history and attendance frequency remain consistent across both groups (Appendix E). Christians in both settings demonstrate growing resistance to regime-aligned information as time since conversion and church attendance increase. This uniform pattern aligns with Doshay, who demonstrates that political orientation rarely determines initial church affiliation (Doshay, 2021). Ultimately, resistance to state propaganda intensifies in both institutional environments as believers become more deeply embedded in their faith communities.

Conclusion

This paper argues that when politically distrusted groups promote pro-regime propaganda, they can reduce perceived threats from outsiders by signaling conformity to the political status quo, but at the cost of alienating in-group members who see such messaging as incompatible with their religious beliefs. Drawing on Christians in China as a case study, I employ evidence from two original experiments to support the argument.

This study has two limitations. First, it relies on sermon titles with explicit political themes to identify instances of pro-regime propaganda, potentially overlooking subtler forms of political influence. Observational research on Catholic priests in Communist Poland, for example, finds that co-opted clergy could shape believers' attitudes toward the government without diminishing church attendance, suggesting that promoting regime-aligned ideas did not necessarily erode religious credibility (Nalepa and Pop-Eleches, 2022). While political messaging in Chinese churches is often more overt, it remains possible that some Christian leaders succeed in balancing propaganda promotion with retaining congregational trust.

Second, the Chinese authoritarian regime currently enjoys relatively high levels of public support. Although survey data may overstate this support due to self-censorship and social

desirability bias, recent research employing bias-mitigating techniques confirms that the Chinese Communist Party retains substantial popular backing (Nicholson and Huang, 2022). My findings suggest that, by aligning with a broadly popular regime, Christians who promote pro-regime messaging gain greater social acceptance. Whether these dynamics hold under authoritarian regimes with weaker legitimacy remains an open question for future research.

This study sheds light on the precarious balance that leaders of politically marginalized groups must strike between gaining outsider acceptance and maintaining insider trust. Living under a hostile environment, religious minority groups often find it crucial for their survival and growth to appeal to outsiders. However, such accommodation might lead to alienation of followers, as it can be perceived as sacrificing religious integrity in exchange for external approval.

This dilemma also illuminates the role of religious organizations in democratization. Extant research links Protestantism to the rise of modern democracy (Woodberry, 2012; Gerring et al., 2022). In Latin America (Gill, 1998), South Korea (Im, 2020) and Taiwan (Rubinstein, 2015), Christian leaders at times actively supported and facilitated democratic transitions. Many observers, therefore, expected Chinese Christians to play a similar role, yet they have largely remained politically compliant (Aikman, 2006). My study argues that perceptions of Christianity as a “Western” faith are pivotal. In Korea and Taiwan, despite Christians’ minority status, the historical domestication of Christianity means it is not widely seen as a foreign religion tied to a national adversary; nationalist frames thus struggle to cast churches as subversive. In China, by contrast, persistent suspicions of foreign affiliation narrow Christians’ political space and limit their capacity to advocate for change.

The findings also have broader implications for understanding state–society relations and the co-optation of social leaders and organizations under authoritarian rule. Under such regimes, co-opted unions and religious bodies often function as instruments of state control and reinforce the existing power structure (Kim and Gandhi, 2010; Mattingly, 2019; Jamal, 2009), rather than as genuine vehicles of civic participation (Putnam et al., 1994). This

paper suggests that when the state transforms civil society leaders into its agents, these organizations gradually lose the trust and influence they hold among their constituents. Over time, dissatisfaction with these compromised institutions can create space for independent alternatives to emerge.²¹

In the specific case of China, this study suggests that the politicization of religion might help some churches, especially those under the corporatist TSPM system, expand their public appeal and attract new members without undermining the trust of less devout congregants. However, more devout members, disillusioned by overt political messaging, may leave these churches in favor of less politicized, independent alternatives. In the long term, this dynamic could contribute to religious polarization within the Christian community, as more pious believers withdraw from TSPM churches and join house churches that insist on maintaining independence and reject affiliation with the Three-Self Patriotic Movement.

²¹Civil organizations often splinter over attitudes toward the authoritarian regime. In the Soviet Union, Catacomb Churches arose in response to Patriarchal Metropolitan Sergius's pledge of loyalty to the Communist regime. Similar dynamics can be seen in labor movements, such as Solidarity in Communist Poland and the Coordinadora Nacional de Trabajadores de la Educación in PRI-dominated Mexico, both of which rejected official corporatist unions in favor of independent organizations.

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Appendix A Demographic Distribution of the Sample

Table A.1: Survey Respondents’ Demographic Distribution

Variable	Category	Study 1 Non-religious	Study 2	Study 1 Christian	CFPS
Gender	Male	48.90%	46.80%	38.60%	50.00%
Gender	Female	51.10%	53.20%	61.40%	50.00%
Age Group	18 - 30	33.20%	37.90%	35.00%	26.60%
Age Group	30 - 45	37.10%	29.60%	48.30%	18.20%
Age Group	46 - 55	18.80%	23.80%	15.00%	22.60%
Age Group	Above 56	11.00%	8.70%	1.60%	32.60%
Region	Eastern	33.60%	31.20%	35.70%	18.70%
Region	North	16.10%	15.70%	14.20%	13.80%
Region	North Eastern	6.60%	7.00%	7.00%	12.30%
Region	North Western	5.60%	5.00%	3.30%	14.90%
Region	South Central	29.40%	30.80%	31.00%	28.10%
Region	South Western	8.60%	10.40%	8.90%	12.00%

Note: Study 1 (2024–2025 survey) and Study 2 (camera vignette experiment). CFPS data are from the 2022 China Family Panel Studies as a national benchmark.

Appendix B Measures for Nationalism

To measure nationalism, I adopt three questions from Huang and Liu (2018), which examines nationalism in the Chinese context. These questions ask respondents: (1) whether they believe Chinese culture is superior to most other cultures globally; (2) whether they agree that people should support their country regardless of whether its actions are right or wrong; and (3) whether they agree with the statement, “A century of humiliation describes both the past and how foreigners are treating China now.” Each question offers four response options: strongly disagree, somewhat disagree, somewhat agree, and strongly agree.

I use Principal Component Analysis (PCA) to analyze responses to these three items. The results indicate that the questions capture a common underlying dimension of nationalist sentiment, with the first principal component explaining 53% of the variance.

Table A.2: PCA Summary

Component	Eigenvalue	Variance Explained	Cumulative Variance
PC1	0.93	0.53	0.53
PC2	0.68	0.28	0.81
PC3	0.57	0.19	1.00

Appendix C Full AMCE Results

Appendix C.1 Non-religious Respondents

Table A.3: Full AMCE on Non-Religious Respondents

Attribute	Level	Authority	Recruitment	Patriotism
Age	49	0.070*** (0.011)	0.057*** (0.012)	0.031 (0.028)
Age	65	0.092*** (0.012)	0.066*** (0.012)	−0.006 (0.029)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	0.031** (0.011)	0.037** (0.011)	−0.005 (0.026)
Education	US Seminary PhD	−0.050*** (0.012)	−0.049*** (0.012)	−0.386*** (0.031)
Gender	Male	−0.016 (0.009)	−0.001 (0.010)	−0.010 (0.022)
Position	Seminary Professor	0.015 (0.012)	0.023* (0.011)	0.031 (0.028)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	0.025* (0.012)	0.051*** (0.012)	0.192*** (0.030)
Sermon	Propaganda	0.156*** (0.012)	0.189*** (0.012)	1.454*** (0.033)

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. Stars: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Table A.4: AMCE Estimates by Trust in Christians

Attribute	Level	Authority		Recruitment		Patriotism	
		Not Trusting	Trusting	Not Trusting	Trusting	Not Trusting	Trusting
Age	49	0.052*** (0.015)	0.099*** (0.018)	0.048*** (0.015)	0.071*** (0.019)	-0.018 (0.038)	0.116** (0.038)
Age	65	0.085*** (0.015)	0.103*** (0.019)	0.058*** (0.015)	0.077*** (0.020)	-0.005 (0.038)	0.005 (0.043)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	0.035* (0.014)	0.026 (0.019)	0.042** (0.014)	0.028 (0.018)	-0.001 (0.036)	-0.002 (0.037)
Education	US Seminary PhD	-0.044** (0.016)	-0.058** (0.020)	-0.045** (0.015)	-0.055** (0.020)	-0.406*** (0.040)	-0.347*** (0.046)
Gender	Male	-0.006 (0.012)	-0.031* (0.015)	-0.010 (0.012)	0.012 (0.016)	-0.019 (0.029)	0.005 (0.032)
Position	Seminary Professor	0.018 (0.015)	0.013 (0.019)	0.020 (0.015)	0.024 (0.018)	0.018 (0.036)	0.071 (0.044)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	0.029 (0.016)	0.018 (0.020)	0.061*** (0.015)	0.034 (0.019)	0.175*** (0.038)	0.219*** (0.046)
Sermon	Propaganda	0.198*** (0.015)	0.092*** (0.020)	0.234*** (0.014)	0.120*** (0.019)	1.592*** (0.044)	1.222*** (0.049)

Note: Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Table A.5: AMCE Estimates by Nationalism

Attribute	Level	Authority		Recruitment		Patriotism	
		Low Nat	High Nat	Low Nat	High Nat	Low Nat	High Nat
Age	49	0.071*** (0.016)	0.065*** (0.016)	0.050** (0.016)	0.065*** (0.016)	0.035 (0.038)	0.031 (0.040)
Age	65	0.085*** (0.017)	0.097*** (0.017)	0.074*** (0.017)	0.059*** (0.017)	0.022 (0.039)	-0.035 (0.043)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	0.052** (0.016)	0.013 (0.016)	0.050** (0.016)	0.022 (0.016)	0.008 (0.036)	-0.012 (0.038)
Education	US Seminary PhD	-0.001 (0.017)	-0.099*** (0.017)	0.018 (0.017)	-0.118*** (0.017)	-0.392*** (0.042)	-0.377*** (0.045)
Gender	Male	0.003 (0.013)	-0.036** (0.013)	-0.013 (0.014)	0.010 (0.013)	-0.013 (0.030)	-0.010 (0.032)
Position	Seminary Professor	0.015 (0.017)	0.015 (0.017)	0.026 (0.016)	0.019 (0.016)	0.018 (0.037)	0.045 (0.043)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	0.012 (0.017)	0.039* (0.018)	0.038* (0.017)	0.065*** (0.017)	0.199*** (0.040)	0.184*** (0.044)
Sermon Title	Propaganda	0.103*** (0.017)	0.212*** (0.017)	0.151*** (0.016)	0.230*** (0.016)	1.390*** (0.047)	1.517*** (0.047)

Note: Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Appendix C.2 Christian Sample

Table A.6: Full AMCE: Christians

Attribute	Level	Authority	Recruitment
Age	49	0.019 (0.014)	0.046*** (0.014)
Age	65	0.073*** (0.013)	0.063*** (0.014)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	−0.010 (0.013)	0.005 (0.013)
Education	US Seminary PhD	−0.030* (0.014)	0.010 (0.013)
Gender	Male	−0.001 (0.011)	−0.006 (0.011)
Position	Seminary Professor	−0.024 (0.013)	−0.008 (0.013)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	−0.021 (0.014)	−0.011 (0.014)
Sermon	Propaganda	0.023 (0.014)	0.026 (0.013)

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. Stars: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Table A.7: AMCE Estimates by Years Since Conversion

Attribute	Level	Authority			Recruitment		
		Below 5	5–10	Over 10	Below 5	5–10	Over 10
Age	49	0.034 (0.020)	−0.005 (0.025)	0.026 (0.028)	0.036 (0.021)	0.036 (0.024)	0.086** (0.028)
Age	65	0.062** (0.019)	0.062** (0.024)	0.112*** (0.030)	0.058** (0.020)	0.060* (0.025)	0.077* (0.031)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	−0.019 (0.020)	−0.000 (0.024)	−0.015 (0.027)	−0.010 (0.019)	−0.002 (0.024)	0.044 (0.027)
Education	US Seminary PhD	−0.021 (0.021)	−0.018 (0.025)	−0.066* (0.028)	0.020 (0.019)	−0.065** (0.024)	0.089** (0.028)
Gender	Male	−0.008 (0.015)	0.020 (0.019)	−0.019 (0.022)	−0.012 (0.017)	−0.010 (0.019)	0.013 (0.023)
Position	Seminary Professor	−0.017 (0.020)	−0.065** (0.022)	0.008 (0.028)	−0.025 (0.020)	−0.015 (0.023)	0.036 (0.028)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	−0.007 (0.021)	−0.024 (0.025)	−0.050 (0.030)	−0.018 (0.020)	−0.007 (0.024)	−0.006 (0.029)
Sermon	Propaganda	0.085*** (0.020)	0.029 (0.023)	−0.108*** (0.029)	0.071*** (0.019)	0.041 (0.023)	−0.082** (0.031)

Note: Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Table A.8: AMCE Estimates by Church Attendance

Attribute	Level	Authority			Recruitment		
		< Monthly	Monthly	Weekly	< Monthly	Monthly	Weekly
Age	49	0.022 (0.023)	0.027 (0.022)	0.006 (0.027)	0.041 (0.023)	0.043* (0.021)	0.058* (0.028)
Age	65	0.084*** (0.022)	0.090*** (0.023)	0.034 (0.025)	0.051* (0.023)	0.071** (0.023)	0.067* (0.028)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	0.005 (0.022)	-0.023 (0.022)	-0.015 (0.027)	0.018 (0.022)	-0.019 (0.022)	0.023 (0.024)
Education	US Seminary PhD	-0.007 (0.023)	-0.023 (0.023)	-0.073* (0.029)	0.030 (0.022)	0.019 (0.021)	-0.030 (0.027)
Gender	Male	-0.003 (0.017)	0.009 (0.018)	-0.015 (0.021)	-0.020 (0.018)	-0.009 (0.018)	0.013 (0.021)
Position	Seminary Professor	-0.023 (0.022)	-0.035 (0.022)	-0.008 (0.027)	-0.010 (0.023)	0.006 (0.021)	-0.025 (0.026)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	-0.026 (0.024)	-0.020 (0.023)	-0.015 (0.028)	-0.023 (0.024)	0.001 (0.022)	-0.013 (0.025)
Sermon	Propaganda	0.014 (0.023)	0.061** (0.021)	-0.022 (0.029)	0.054* (0.022)	0.062** (0.021)	-0.067* (0.028)

Note: Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Appendix D Robustness Checks

Appendix D.1 Subgroup Analysis by Demographic Traits

The demographic distribution of my sample is not nationally representative of the population. Although, as I explained in the main body of the paper, this imbalance should not affect our inferences, the subgroup analysis helps address concerns by confirming that no major subgroup differences exist across key demographic traits.

For the subgroup analysis, I focus on gender and age and present the results in Tables A13 through A16. Among non-religious respondents, younger and male individuals exhibit a stronger preference for propaganda-promoting Christian leaders. However, the coefficients across all subgroups remain directionally consistent with the main analysis, suggesting that the underrepresentation of older individuals and men does not affect the main results. Among Christians, no significant subgroup differences emerge, indicating that differences in conversion history and church attendance are not driven by demographic traits.

Table A.9: AMCE Estimates by Age Group (Non-religious)

Attribute	Level	Authority		Recruitment		Patriotism	
		Younger	Older	Younger	Older	Younger	Older
Age	49	0.057*** (0.016)	0.085*** (0.016)	0.048** (0.016)	0.066*** (0.017)	0.021 (0.039)	0.037 (0.040)
Age	65	0.094*** (0.016)	0.092*** (0.018)	0.060*** (0.017)	0.071*** (0.017)	-0.011 (0.040)	0.001 (0.041)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	0.047** (0.015)	0.015 (0.017)	0.037* (0.015)	0.038* (0.017)	0.044 (0.036)	-0.060 (0.038)
Education	US Seminary PhD	-0.044** (0.017)	-0.056** (0.018)	-0.043* (0.017)	-0.053** (0.018)	-0.406*** (0.043)	-0.366*** (0.044)
Gender	Male	-0.019 (0.013)	-0.012 (0.013)	0.003 (0.013)	-0.004 (0.014)	-0.012 (0.030)	-0.007 (0.033)
Position	Seminary Professor	0.024 (0.016)	0.005 (0.018)	0.013 (0.016)	0.033* (0.016)	0.020 (0.039)	0.044 (0.041)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	0.036* (0.017)	0.012 (0.018)	0.056*** (0.016)	0.044* (0.017)	0.190*** (0.041)	0.189*** (0.042)
Sermon Title	Propaganda	0.200*** (0.016)	0.109*** (0.018)	0.240*** (0.015)	0.135*** (0.017)	1.539*** (0.046)	1.363*** (0.048)

Note: Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Table A.10: AMCE Estimates by Gender (Non-religious)

Attribute	Level	Authority		Recruitment		Patriotism	
		Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male
Age	49	0.054*** (0.016)	0.088*** (0.016)	0.044** (0.015)	0.072*** (0.017)	0.031 (0.038)	0.028 (0.041)
Age	65	0.075*** (0.017)	0.110*** (0.017)	0.075*** (0.017)	0.058*** (0.017)	-0.023 (0.040)	0.013 (0.042)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	0.018 (0.015)	0.046** (0.017)	0.053*** (0.016)	0.020 (0.016)	0.022 (0.037)	-0.036 (0.038)
Education	US Seminary PhD	-0.052** (0.017)	-0.048** (0.018)	-0.052** (0.017)	-0.045* (0.018)	-0.368*** (0.042)	-0.407*** (0.045)
Gender	Male	-0.032* (0.013)	0.001 (0.013)	-0.017 (0.014)	0.016 (0.014)	-0.049 (0.030)	0.034 (0.033)
Position	Seminary Professor	0.023 (0.016)	0.006 (0.017)	0.026 (0.016)	0.020 (0.016)	0.036 (0.038)	0.024 (0.042)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	0.037* (0.017)	0.012 (0.018)	0.043** (0.016)	0.059*** (0.018)	0.142*** (0.040)	0.246*** (0.043)
Sermon Title	Propaganda	0.149*** (0.018)	0.165*** (0.017)	0.170*** (0.016)	0.210*** (0.017)	1.444*** (0.044)	1.464*** (0.050)

Note: Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Table A.11: AMCE Estimates by Age Group (Christians)

Attribute	Level	Authority		Recruitment	
		Younger	Older	Younger	Older
Age	49	0.023 (0.019)	0.015 (0.020)	0.055** (0.019)	0.036 (0.020)
Age	65	0.086*** (0.019)	0.060** (0.019)	0.095*** (0.020)	0.031 (0.020)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	0.001 (0.019)	-0.022 (0.019)	-0.011 (0.018)	0.021 (0.019)
Education	US Seminary PhD	-0.031 (0.020)	-0.029 (0.020)	-0.013 (0.019)	0.033 (0.018)
Gender	Male	0.004 (0.015)	-0.008 (0.015)	-0.019 (0.015)	0.005 (0.016)
Position	Seminary Professor	-0.001 (0.019)	-0.048* (0.019)	0.024 (0.019)	-0.040* (0.019)
Position	CPPCC Committee Vice Chairman	-0.007 (0.020)	-0.037 (0.020)	0.006 (0.019)	-0.028 (0.020)
Sermon Title	Propaganda	0.026 (0.019)	0.021 (0.019)	0.045* (0.020)	0.006 (0.018)

Note:

Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Table A.12: AMCE Estimates by Gender (Christians)

Attribute	Level	Authority		Recruitment	
		Female	Male	Female	Male
Age	49	0.042* (0.017)	-0.018 (0.023)	0.043* (0.017)	0.050* (0.023)
Age	65	0.092*** (0.017)	0.042 (0.022)	0.065*** (0.018)	0.059* (0.023)
Education	Chinese Seminary PhD	-0.005 (0.017)	-0.017 (0.022)	-0.001 (0.017)	0.014 (0.022)
Education	US Seminary PhD	-0.031 (0.018)	-0.027 (0.022)	0.011 (0.017)	0.006 (0.021)
Gender	Male	-0.003 (0.013)	0.001 (0.018)	-0.019 (0.015)	0.014 (0.017)
Position	Seminary Professor	-0.046** (0.017)	0.011 (0.022)	-0.010 (0.017)	-0.007 (0.022)
Position	CPPCC Vice Chairman	-0.040* (0.018)	0.009 (0.023)	-0.023 (0.018)	0.006 (0.022)
Sermon	Propaganda	0.039* (0.018)	-0.002 (0.021)	0.026 (0.017)	0.025 (0.021)

Note: Standard errors clustered at the respondent level in parentheses. Stars indicate significance: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Reference categories: Age (33), Gender (Female), Position (Nursing House Director), Education (Chinese Seminary Bachelor), Sermon Title (Non-Propaganda).

Appendix D.2 Interaction Model Controlling for Age

I further examine whether the observed treatment heterogeneity among Christians is driven by age, given that older individuals tend to attend church more frequently and are more likely to have a longer conversion history. To rule out this possibility, I compare models that include interactions between church attendance or conversion history and profile attributes with models that additionally include interactions with age group (Tables A.3 and A.4). In both models, all attributes interact with the moderators. The coefficients of the interaction terms between sermon attribute values and the moderators, conversion time and church attendance, remain essentially unchanged, suggesting that the treatment heterogeneity by church attendance and conversion time is not driven by age difference.

Table A.13: Subgroup Effects by Conversion Length Controlling for Age

Dependent Variable:	Authority		Recruitment	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Main effect (Ref: Below 5 years)				
Sermon Title: Propaganda	0.0850*** (0.0201)	0.0992*** (0.0264)	0.0714*** (0.0191)	0.0597* (0.0251)
Interaction: 5–10 years				
Propaganda $\times$ 5–10 years	−0.0558 (0.0303)	−0.0600 (0.0308)	−0.0300 (0.0297)	−0.0272 (0.0305)
Interaction: Over 10 years				
Propaganda $\times$ Over 10 years	−0.1934*** (0.0354)	−0.1986*** (0.0361)	−0.1530*** (0.0363)	−0.1486*** (0.0369)
Interaction: Younger people				
Propaganda $\times$ Younger people		−0.0226 (0.0274)		0.0185 (0.0274)
Observations	8,756	8,756	8,760	8,760
Attributes Interactions with	No	Yes	No	Yes
Age				
R ²	0.013	0.014	0.011	0.013

Note: Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Significance codes: *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$

Reference level for Conversion History is 'Below 5 years'.

Reference level for Sermon Title is 'Non-propaganda'.

All models control for profile attributes (Age, Edu, Gender, Position).

Table A.14: Subgroup Effects by Church Attendance Controlling for Age

Dependent Variable:	Authority		Recruitment	
Model:	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Main effect (Ref: Less than monthly attendance				
Sermon Title: Propaganda	0.0138 (0.0227)	0.0092 (0.0265)	0.054* (0.0222)	0.0332 (0.0254)
Interaction: Monthly attendance				
Propaganda × Monthly attendance	0.0477 (0.0308)	0.0490 (0.0309)	0.0075 (0.0304)	0.0095 (0.0305)
Interaction: Weekly attendance				
Propaganda × Weekly attendance	-0.0359 (0.0364)	-0.0350 (0.0364)	-0.1211*** (0.0356)	-0.1228*** (0.0356)
Interaction: Younger people				
Propaganda × Younger people		0.0079 (0.0272)		0.0408 (0.0268)
Observations	8,756	8,756	8,760	8,760
Attributes Interactions with	No	Yes	No	Yes
Age				
R ²	0.008	0.008	0.008	0.011

Note: Standard errors are clustered at the respondent level.

Significance codes: *** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$

Reference level for Sermon Title is 'Non-propaganda'.

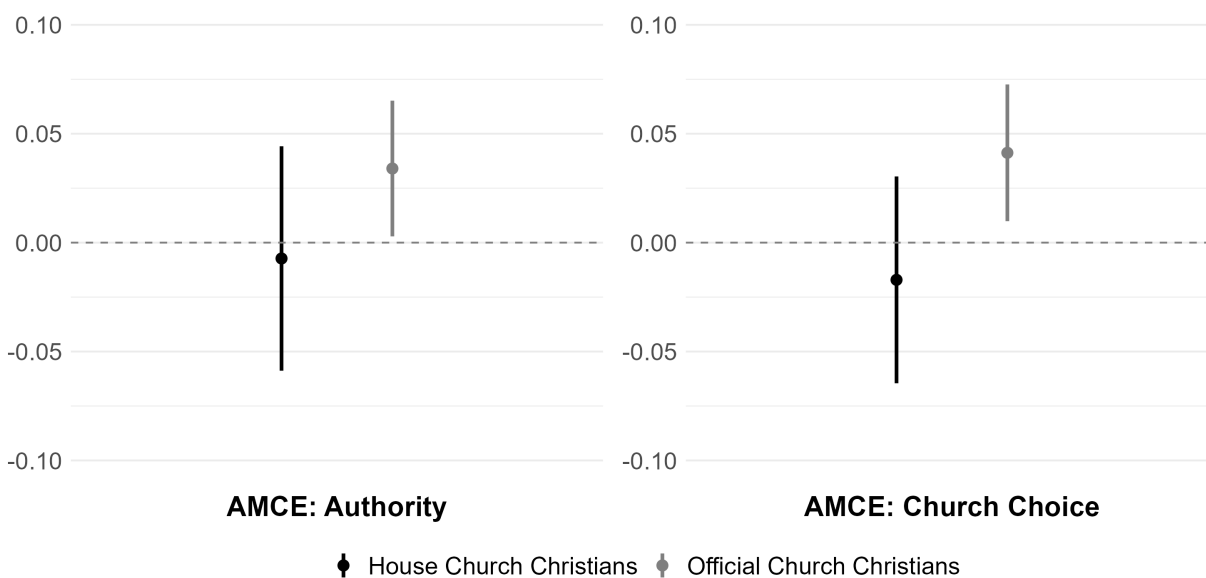
All models control for profile attributes (Age, Edu, Gender, Position).

Appendix E Discussion on the Difference between House Church Christians and Official Church Christians

In China, a significant proportion of Christians attend churches that operate outside the direct control of the government. Contrary to common depictions of house churches as hardened opponents of the Chinese Communist Party, the community categorized under this label is highly diverse. While certain groups exhibit greater hostility toward the state, notably rural churches that emerged during the severe persecution of the Cultural Revolution and specific urban congregations influenced by American Evangelicalism, the majority maintain a more politically ambiguous stance. For most new converts, the decision to join an official church or a house church is generally not driven by political considerations (Doshay, 2021).

Do house-church Christians and official church Christians react to regime-aligned information from their faith leaders differently? I explored heterogeneity based on the distinction between Christians attending state-sanctioned (official) churches and unregistered (house) churches. Of the 1,100 Christian respondents, roughly 800 attend official churches, while less than 300 attend house churches. On average, as Figure A.1 shows, official church attendees are slightly more receptive to regime-aligned messages than house church attendees.

Figure A.1: AMCE by Church Type



Subgroup analyses based on the two moderators discussed in the main text, conversion duration and frequency of church attendance, reveal a consistent pattern in Figure A.2. Christians with more than ten years of conversion history and those who attend church weekly exhibit the strongest resistance to pro-regime propaganda. Although Christians in official churches often maintain favorable views toward pastors who promote state propaganda, these

results suggest that religious socialization operates through similar mechanisms within both government-sanctioned and independent churches. Consequently, the moderating effects observed are not driven by the specific type of church an individual attends.

Figure A.2: Subgroup Analysis by Conversion Time by Church Type

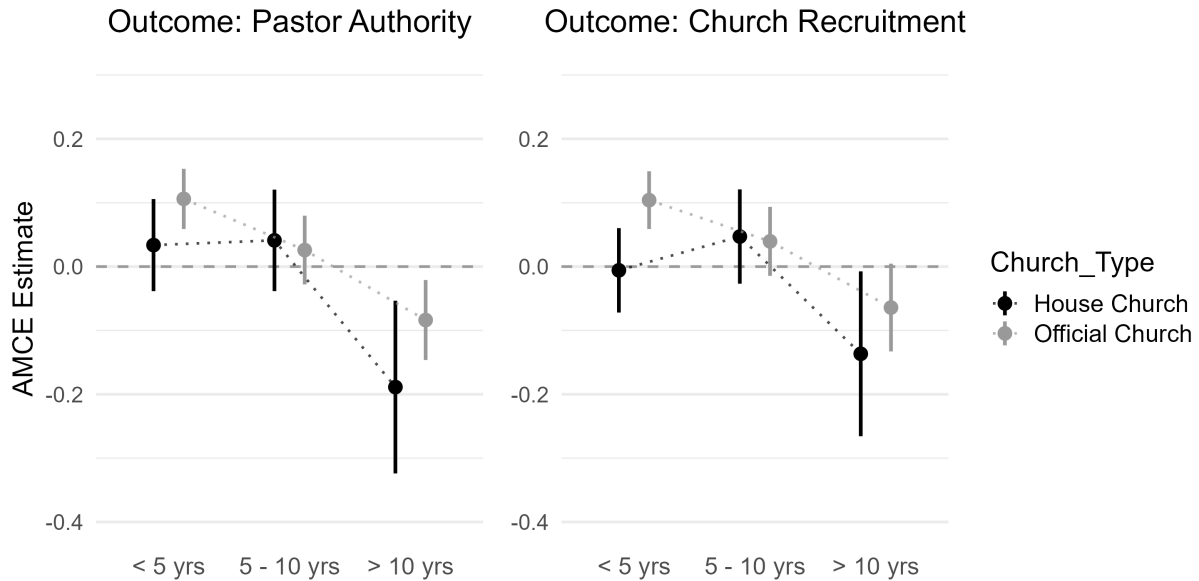


Figure A.3: Subgroup Analysis by Attendance Frequency by Church Type



Appendix F IRB Approval



Office of Research Support & Compliance
Institutional Review Board
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EXEMPT DETERMINATION

December 13, 2023

FWA # 00002030

Xiaobo Lu
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Dear Xiaobo Lu:

On 12/13/2023, the IRB reviewed the following submission:

Type of Review:	Initial Study
Special Determinations:	None
Title:	Study on the Satisfaction of Religious Personnel
Investigator:	Xiaobo Lu
IRB ID:	STUDY00005311
Funding:	None
Grant ID:	None
IND, IDE, or HDE:	None
Approval Date:	12/13/2023
Documents Reviewed:	• HRP - UT902 - IRB Proposal Exempt Submission (1) (1).docx, Category: IRB Protocol; • HRP - UT926 - Template Exempt Information Sheet IRB edits.pdf, Category: Consent Form; • Survey, Category: Other;

The IRB determined that this protocol meets the criteria for exemption from IRB review under 45 CFR 46.104 (2)(ii) Tests, surveys, interviews, or observation (low risk)(3)(i)(B) Benign behavioral interventions (low risk).

In conducting this protocol, you are required to follow the requirements listed in the Investigator Manual (HRP-103) and UT IRB Policies and Procedures (HRP-UT1000), which can be found by navigating to the IRB Library, General tab, within UTRMS-IRB.

Ongoing IRB review and approval by this organization is not required. This determination applies only to the activities described in the IRB submission and does not apply should any changes be made. Modifications that involve a change in PI, increase risk, or otherwise affect the exempt category or the criteria for exempt determination must be submitted as a modification. Investigators are strongly encouraged to contact the IRB staff to describe any changes prior to submitting an amendment/modification.

If you have any questions, contact the RSC by phone at 512 -232-1543 or via e-mail at irb@austin.utexas.edu.

Sincerely,

Institutional Review Board

University of Texas at Austin

cc:

Xiaobo Lu (PI), Kenny Miao (Primary Contact), Kenny Miao (Proxy)